

Incident Runbook Automated Employee Onboarding

Severity	SEV 2 by default • Raise to SEV 1 for security, data-integrity, or broad service impact
Critical flow	Employee creation → Cognito identity → document collection → provisioning → welcome email

Alarm meaning Error-rate alarm: more than 5% Lambda errors for two consecutive 5-minute periods. Latency alarm: Lambda P95 duration above 3,000 ms for two consecutive 5-minute periods.

POSSIBLE CAUSES

- 401: expired/invalid Cognito JWT; 403: HR/admin group or route permission mismatch
- Cognito user creation, duplicate username, quota, or permission error
- Missing employee data/document or Step Functions retry exhaustion
- DynamoDB single-writer, S3, IAM, or KMS AccessDenied
- Cognito/SES delay, workflow wait state, or downstream latency

BUSINESS IMPACT

New hires may not receive access, required steps may remain incomplete, Day-1 readiness can be delayed, and HR may see incorrect onboarding status.

FIRST RESPONSE

1. Acknowledge the alert and capture employee ID, execution ARN, failed state, UTC time, and region.
2. For 401/403, validate JWT expiry/issuer/audience, HR/admin group claim, Cognito authorizer, and protected-route configuration.
3. Use logs, X-Ray, and execution history to isolate the task; for AccessDenied, verify the exact table/bucket/KMS ARN on the execution role.
4. Check whether accounts/assets were partially provisioned before retrying; prevent duplicate users, assets, or emails.
5. Correct the issue, then resume/redrive from the failed state when supported or start a controlled compensating workflow.

RECOVERY VERIFICATION

- Confirm each mandatory workflow state completes and dashboard status is accurate.
- Verify one Cognito user, correct document status, asset/account state, and one welcome email.
- Confirm alarm is OK for two periods and no executions remain unexpectedly stuck.

ESCALATION CONDITIONS

- Critical onboarding is blocked or breach persists for 15 minutes.
- Partial provisioning cannot be reconciled, credentials were exposed, or duplicate identities/assets exist.
- An AWS regional issue, IAM/KMS failure, or security incident is suspected.

Recovery evidence to attach Alarm history; execution ARN; failed-state input/output with PII redacted; user ID; test employee ID; recovery timeline.